

Split-brain patients have no connection between the left and the right sides of their brains, which prevents information from being shared between the two cerebral hemispheres. These patients are jewels, rare and invaluable for researchers. You literally have two different persons, and you can communicate with each one of them separately; the differences between the two individuals give you some indication about the specialization of each of the hemispheres. This splitting is usually the result of surgery to remedy more serious conditions like severe epilepsy; no, scientists in Western countries (and most Eastern ones) are no longer allowed to cut human brains in half, even if it is for the pursuit of knowledge and wisdom.

Now, say that you induced such a person to perform an act—raise his finger, laugh, or grab a shovel—in order to ascertain how he ascribes a reason to his act (when in fact you know that there is no reason for it other than your inducing it). If you ask the right hemisphere, here isolated from the left side, to perform the action, then ask the other hemisphere for an explanation, the patient will invariably offer some interpretation: “I was pointing at the ceiling in order to ...,” “I saw something interesting on the wall,” or, if you ask this author, I will offer my usual “because I am originally from the Greek Orthodox village of Amioun, northern Lebanon,” et cetera.

Now, if you do the opposite, namely instruct the isolated left hemisphere of a right-handed person to perform an act and ask the right hemisphere for the reasons, you will be plainly told, “I don’t know.” Note that the left hemisphere is where language and deduction generally reside. I warn the reader hungry for “science” against attempts to build a neural map: all I’m trying to show is the biological basis of this tendency toward causality, not its precise location. There are reasons for us to be suspicious of these “right brain/left brain” distinctions and subsequent pop-science generalizations about personality. Indeed, the idea that the left brain controls language may not be so accurate: the left brain seems more precisely to be where pattern interpretation resides, and it may control language only insofar as language has a pattern-interpretation attribute. Another difference between the hemispheres is that the right brain deals with novelty. It tends to see the gestalt (the general, or the forest), in a parallel mode, while the left brain is concerned with the trees, in a serial mode.

To see an illustration of our biological dependence on a story, consider the following experiment. First, read this:

A BIRD IN THE
THE HAND IS WORTH
TWO IN THE BUSH

Do you see anything unusual? Try again.*